DECKBORN

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Unreal Engine 5.8 | Blueprint-only | A game by Clay Buiocchi

Target Deliverable

> Create a game with deckbuilding combat that includes open world exploration instead of a node-based roguelike map.




DRAGON QUEST






Amber
Lisa
Kaeya
@Pluto
UID: 910689




Attack
Abilities
Spells
Items
Defend
Equipment
Tactics
Elmon
Erik
Serena
Veronica



Overview

Deckborn is a 3D single-player deckbuilding RPG. You explore a valley in third person, get caught by wandering monsters, and fight them by dragging cards onto them.

Genre and Theme

- **Genre:** Single-player deckbuilder with overworld exploration and turn-based card combat
- **Subgenre:** Roguelike-adjacent run structure: one sitting, no save, no meta-progression
- **Theme:** Heroic power fantasy
- **Aesthetic:** Colorful JRPG artstyle, closest comparables are Dragon Quest XI and Genshin Impact.

Target Audience and Platform

- **Audience:** Card enthusiasts who want an experience with a scope that expands beyond the usual node-based roguelike path, as well as fans of RPGs who want a different type of turn-based combat.
- **Platform:** PC
- **Input:** Keyboard and mouse.
- **Length:** About 15-30 minutes

Design Pillars

Pillar	What it means in the build
Exploration	A real 3D world you walk through, not a map of nodes.
Cards as magic	Each card is an individual spell the player casts.
Player expression through builds	No class select. What your deck becomes is what you bought and what you cut.

Competitive Landscape

The combat genre is crowded; the wrapper genre is not. The gap Deckborn aims at is the one nobody has taken: turn-based card combat inside a persistent 3D world you actually walk.

Game	Cards	3D world	Combat	Key difference
Slay the Spire 1 / 2	Yes	No, node map	Turn-based cards	The benchmark. No world, no body, no traversal.
Inscryption	Yes	Single room	Turn-based cards	Won by putting a meta-narrative around the cards.
Deckborn	Yes	**Open world**	Turn-based cards	Open world exploration with turn based deck combat

The Core Loop

1. Explore the Valley in third person while a run clock counts down.
2. A roaming enemy notices you, chases you, and catches you on contact.
3. A cinematic card fight resolves.
4. You take the gold, and that enemy is gone from the world for good.
5. You spend at the Shop: buy a card, cut a card, heal, buy a potion.
6. The clock hits 0:00 and the Dungeon takes you.
7. The Dungeon is a fixed gauntlet: three chambers, a two-way fork, the Warlord.

Beating the Warlord ends the run. Dying in the Dungeon costs your one second chance; dying twice ends the run.

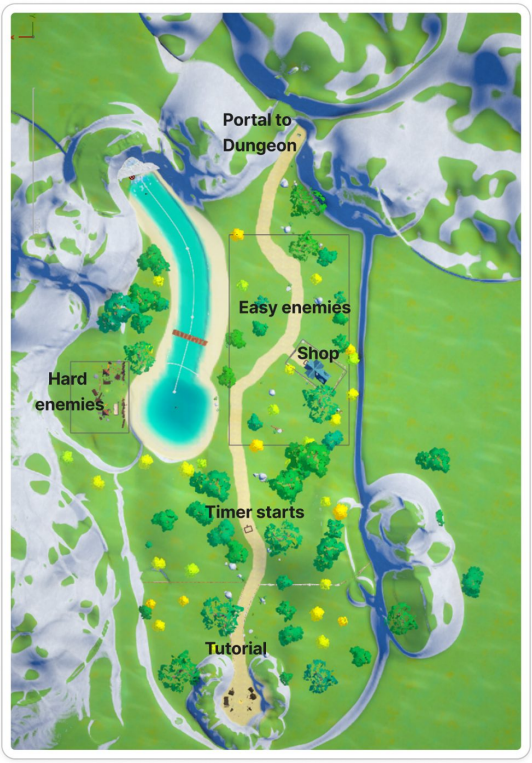
AT A GLANCE

Cards	Enemies	Encounters	Maps	Run clock	Bosses
22	12	13	5	3:00	1

Structure

Map	Role
`L_MainMenu`	Title screen
`L_Valley`	Area in which player can farm gold and spend it at the shop to customize their deck
`L_Dungeon`	The gauntlet that ends with a boss fight
`L_Combat`	Fight stage, Valley backdrop
`L_Dungeon_Combat`	Fight stage, Dungeon backdrop, including the Warlord fight

The Valley



An open valley between the hero's start and the Dungeon gate, under a wide third-person follow camera.

Base camp and Jack

The run opens at a camp at the Valley spawn. Jack, the mentor NPC, stands at the road post; walking into his talk trigger starts his dialogue, and **E** advances it. The camera pushes in on him for the conversation and restores itself afterward. Leaving his dialogue is what starts the run clock. This is so the player can learn what their main objective is before they begin playing.

The Shop

A house off the road; walking into the doorway trigger opens it. This is the only safe spend point in the game.

Roaming enemies

Enemies wander their areas, notice you inside their aggro radius, chase with a short speed burst, then leash home if you break away or drag them too far.

The watchtower camp

A dressed war camp off the main route (stake palisade, market-stall tents, a looted caravan, a cage), garrisoned by Skeletons and Orcs with their own three encounters. It is the Valley's optional high-gold detour.

The waterfall cave

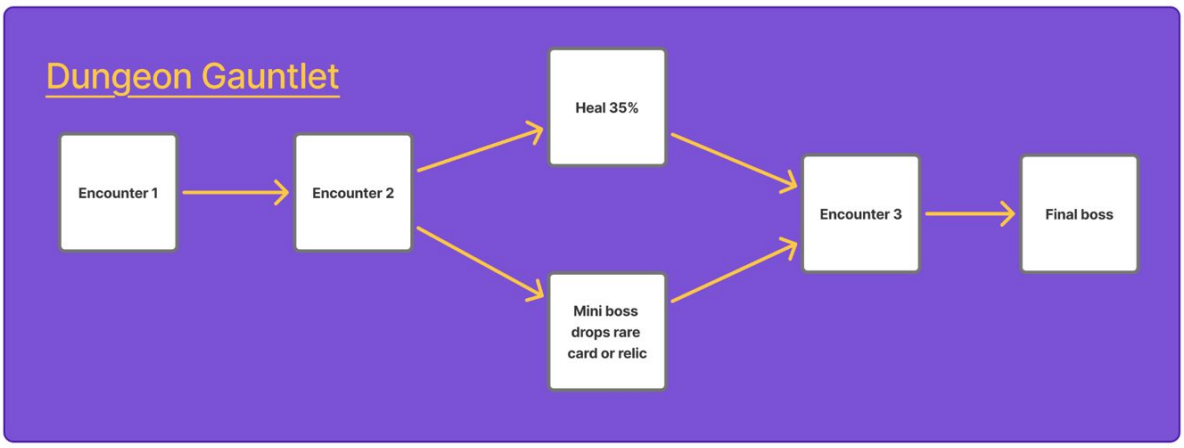
A hidden chamber behind the waterfall, reachable by walking through the falls. A treasure chest inside pays 100 gold once per run.

The Run Clock

A countdown runs in the top-left while you are in the Valley. It is **180 seconds (3:00)** at current tuning, it lives on the run state so it survives a trip into a fight and back, and **it only ticks during Valley exploration..** At 0:00 the game teleports you to the Dungeon whether you are ready or not.

On its first appearance the timer flies in large and centred before settling into its corner, so a first-time player cannot miss that a clock has started.

The Dungeon



A linear gauntlet, denser and harder than the Valley, running its own over-the-shoulder exploration camera.

SEQUENCE

Beat	Contents
Entry	A heal fountain that fully heals you once, then never again
Chamber 1	Skeleton + Evil Mage: a body plus a debuffer
Chamber 2	Bishop Knight + Lizard Warrior: a buff-support fight
The fork	Two doorways: shrine or rat den
Chamber 3 (the Ossuary)	Orc + Evil Mage: the damage wall, in the walled-off western third of the boss hall
Boss approach	The Warlord's intro triggers; the fight runs in L_Dungeon_Combat

Room seals

A stone slab drops behind you as you clear each of the first three chambers. There is no walking back.

The fork

Immediately before encounter 3, the corridor opens into two doorways facing you, and the route forward runs through one of them. A signpost at the junction tells you which is which.

- **Left: the rat den.** Two elite Rat Assassins guarding a chest. Clearing them puts **Black Hole** (Rare, 3 energy, deal 20) into your deck.
- **Right: the shrine.** A fountain that heals a chunk of HP.

Resolving either branch opens the boss gate and destroys the other branch's elites, so the choice seals behind you.

Death, and the One Second Chance

Dying in the Valley is forgiving. Dying in the **Dungeon** is not.

Death	Consequence
Valley, any	Full heal, returned to the Valley, clock untouched
Dungeon, first	Sent back to the Valley in front of the Shop with **60 seconds** on the clock. Spend it or lose it. When it runs out you are pushed straight back into the Dungeon.
Dungeon, second	**The run is over.** The game resets and returns you to the main menu.

Screens and Flow

Screen	When
Main menu	Boot, and after a run ends
Loading screen/Transition	Over every level travel
Skirmish victory	After any ordinary fight
Victory	After the Warlord: the run-ending win, flagged on the encounter itself
Defeat	On death, with a retry that routes through the second-chance rules above
Pause menu	**Escape** or **P**, in exploration, in combat, and over the shop and deck menus
Deck menu	**Q** in exploration

Combat

Combat is a cinematic single-hero card fight. The hero stands screen-left, the enemy line stands screen-right at 250 units of spacing, and you play by dragging cards out of a fanned hand onto them.

Turn Structure

Resource / step	Rule
Hero HP	60 max, carried between fights on the run state
Energy	3 per turn, refilled at the start of each player turn
Draw	5 cards at the start of each player turn
Piles	Draw, hand, discard, and an exhaust pile, all cleared at battle start
Shuffle	The deck is shuffled into the draw pile at battle start
Enemy turn	Enemies act on telegraphed intents, one beat at a time
Block	Cleared at the start of the owner's own turn

Targeting and the Hand

Drag a card and translucent drop slots appear over each living enemy, plus a **Self** slot for self-targeted cards. Targeting reads the **card's** position, not the cursor's, and the card magnet-snaps and shrinks into a slot when it is over one. The slots are royal purple with a gold outline and brighten on hover.

The action queue

You can drop cards while an animation is still playing; they queue and resolve first-in-first-out. The hand does not duck away for every play. It stays put and reacts, while the 3D beat plays out separately.

Potions

Three potion slots sit as colour-coded chips along the bottom of the hero plate, used by clicking or by pressing **1 / 2 / 3**. Health = +12 HP, Energy = +2 energy, Draw = 2 cards. Potions are a combat-only resource; they cannot be used in exploration.

Statuses

Statuses are GameplayTags and show on the enemy plates and the hero HUD. Intents display post-status effective values, and so do card descriptions. A damage number on a card is tinted green or red live to show what it will actually do with your current Strength, and block numbers show the Frail-reduced value.

Status	Exact effect	Decay
Block	Absorbs incoming damage before HP	Cleared at the start of the owner's turn

Status	Exact effect	Decay
Strength	Adds flat damage to every attack the owner makes	**None, lasts the whole fight**
Weak	Owner's outgoing damage × 3/4	−1 per turn
Vulnerable	Owner's incoming damage × 3/2	−1 per turn
Frail	Block the owner gains × 3/4	−1 per turn
Poison	At the owner's upkeep: take damage equal to the stack count	−1 after ticking

Strength is added, then Weak scales it down, then Vulnerable scales it up on the receiving side, then Block absorbs what is left. **Poison bypasses Block entirely**, which is the whole reason the poison archetype exists.

Poison gets its own beat: the victim flinches, a green number pops, purple VFX fire, and the turn waits 0.75s before continuing, so a poison tick reads as an event rather than a silent subtraction.

Card Mechanics

Beyond raw damage and block, the card data supports:

- **Exhaust.** The card leaves play for the rest of the combat (an exhaust pile, not the discard) and comes back next fight.
- **Conditional scaling.** Bonus damage when a condition holds at play time. Fester checks the *target* for Poison; Shield Bash checks *you* for Block.
- **Status doubling.** Toxic Surge doubles the target's current Poison stacks.
- **Block detonation.** Shattering Wall spends all your Block and deals that much to every enemy.
- **Discard as a cost.** Inspiration costs 0 and discards a card from your hand to give you an energy, arming a pending-discard prompt for the choice.
- **All-enemy attacks.** Bomb and Shattering Wall hit the whole line, and the impact VFX fans out to every living enemy.
- **Multi-status application.** A card can apply two different statuses: Rotbind lands Poison and Weak.

Enemy AI

In combat, an enemy picks its next intent from its authored list. Three levers sit on the enemy data asset:

- **Intent weights.** A weighted random draw. Empty weights mean all intents weigh equally, which is why several enemies list the same intent twice to bias the roll. If the weights are all explicitly **zero**, the enemy stops rolling and cycles its intents **in fixed order** instead. That is how the Warlord's clock is built.
- **Low-HP guard threshold.** Below this fraction of max HP, any intent that grants Block is four times more likely. A Shellback under 40% visibly starts bracing.
- **Repeat cap.** An intent that has already repeated this many times in a row is weighted to zero, so nothing hammers the same move forever. Default 2.

The intent line shows more than a damage number: it names incoming statuses, block, and summons.

In the overworld, roamers run a state machine: wander, aggro when you come inside range, chase with a short speed burst, then de-aggro and walk home if you break away or they are pulled too far from where they started. Dungeon roamers are hungrier than Valley ones and are able to catch players who try to cheat by running past them.

Presentation

Combat presentation is a first-class system and it is architecturally separate from the rules. The turn manager resolves the fight and announces what happened; a JuiceManager listens and stages it. **Nothing in the presentation layer can change a number.**

- **The hero animates per card.** The animation is chosen by what the card does (attacks swing, defensive cards brace, utility cards gesture), and any card can override that with its own animation, playback rate and impact timing.
- **Everything lands on the contact frame.** Hit flash, screen punch, hit-stop, enemy flinch, the impact effect, the damage number and the death fall are all timed off the real length of the animation playing.
- **Impacts scale with damage.** A hit weight derived from the damage dealt drives flash intensity, camera shake and SFX pitch jitter, so a 20 lands harder than a 4.
- **Effects.** Niagara VFX on attacks, defences, skills and impacts, colour-coded by function (poison purple/green, shields blue). Cards can carry their own cast, projectile and impact effects: Spirit Slash throws a slash that launches on the cast beat and arrives exactly when damage lands, and the Bomb is lobbed on an arc and explodes on arrival.

The Tutorial Fight

The first Slime fight teaches the player how to drag and drop cards to cast spells. Text appears at the top of the screen in a dialogue box.

Content

Cards

Rarity does two jobs. It sets the shop price (Common 40g / Uncommon 75g / Rare 130g) *and* the odds of the card being offered at all (weights 6 / 3 / 1). A Rare in the window reads as a find, not a purchase decision.

Card	Rarity	Cost	Effect	Source
Spirit Slash	Common	1	Deal 6 damage	Starting deck
Soul Spark	Common	2	Deal 8 damage, gain 1 Strength	Starting deck
Protection Ward	Common	1	Gain 5 Block	Starting deck
Focus	Common	1	Draw 2 cards	Starting deck
Inspiration	Common	0	Discard 1 card, gain 1 energy	Starting deck
Poison Dart	Common	0	Deal 2 damage, apply 2 Poison	Shop
Poison Strike	Common	1	Deal 4 damage, apply 3 Poison	Shop
Weaken	Common	1	Apply 2 Weak	Shop
Shatter	Common	1	Apply 2 Frail	Shop
Stoneskin Rune	Common	2	Gain 12 Block	Shop
Manifest	Common	0	Draw 1 cards	Shop
Venom	Uncommon	1	Apply 6 Poison	Shop
Rotbind	Uncommon	1	Apply 2 Poison and 1 Weak	Shop
Fester	Uncommon	2	Deal 8 damage; +6 if the target is Poisoned	Shop
Flex	Uncommon	1	Gain 4 Block and 1 Strength	Shop
Prayer	Uncommon	1	Gain 3 Block, remove 1 debuff	Shop
Shield Bash	Uncommon	1	Deal 5 damage; +4 if you have Block	Shop
Toxic Surge	Rare	2	Double the target's Poison stacks. Exhaust	Shop
Power Surge	Rare	1	Gain 1 Strength. Exhaust	Shop
Shattering Wall	Rare	1	Lose all Block, deal that much damage to all enemies. Exhaust	Shop
Bomb	Rare	2	Deal 10 damage to all enemies	Shop
Black Hole	Rare	3	Deal 20 damage	**Rat combat reward only**

Black Hole is the only card in the game you cannot buy. It is the reward for taking the greedy fork.

The Starting Deck

Every run starts with the same **12 cards**

Card	Count	Cost	Effect
Spirit Slash	5	1	Deal 6
Protection Ward	4	1	Gain 5 Block
Soul Spark	1	2	Deal 8, gain 1 Strength
Focus	1	1	Draw 2
Inspiration	1	0	Discard 1, gain 1 energy

Archetypes

Archetype	Enablers	Payoffs	How it wins
Strength	Soul Spark, Flex, Power Surge		Player gets stronger overtime, if they are willing to spend the mana
Poison	Poison Dart, Poison Strike, Venom, Rotbind	Fester, Toxic Surge	Slowly and inevitably, and it ignores Block entirely.
Block	Protection Ward, Stoneskin Rune, Flex, Prayer, Power Surge	Shield Bash, Shattering Wall	Outlasts everything, then Shattering Wall turns a turtled turn into a board wipe.
Glue	Weaken, Shatter, Manifest and Bomb serve any direction.		

Enemies

Enemy	HP	Gold	Where	Behaviour
Slime	22	10	Valley	66%: Attack 4, 33%: Acid Spit 3 + 1 Weak. The tutorial fight.
Spider	28	15	Valley	66%: Attack 6, 33%: Block 5. Braces below 40%.HP
Shellback	38	25	Valley	66%: Attack 12, 33%: Block 8. Braces below 40% HP
Skeleton	24	40	Camp / Dungeon	Attack 8, Attack 5 (2 Vulnerable), Block 8.
Orc	32	50	Camp / Dungeon	Attack 9, Attack 11, Blood Rage (+1 Strength to itself).
Evil Mage	24	22	Dungeon	Ally Strength +1, Attack 3 (+ 2 Weak), Curse of Frailty (2 Frail), Attack 10.
Bishop Knight	30	26	Dungeon	Consecrate (+2 Strength to an ally), Attack 7, Block 13.. Braces below 45%.
Lizard Warrior	36	28	Dungeon	Attack 7, Attack 12, Block 10. Braces below 45%.

Enemy	HP	Gold	Where	Behaviour
Rat Assassin	45	—	Dungeon fork elite	Elite. Rusted Daggers 8, Venom Flask (5 + 1 Poison), Shadowstep (8 Block + 1 Weak). Braces below 35%. Comes as a pair; the chest is the reward, not gold.
Warlord	**90**	**100**	Dungeon boss	See below.
Risen Skeleton	24	—	Summon only	Attack 4.
Bound Hexer	24	—	Summon only	Ally Strength +1, Attack 3 (+ 2 Weak), Hex (+2 Vulnerable).

The two summons carry no gold reward, because they are not a fight you chose.

Encounters

Encounter	Enemies	Where
Tutorial	Slime	Valley
Slime Pack	Slime ×2	Valley
Spider	Spider	Valley
Brute Guard	Shellback	Valley
Bridge	Shellback + Spider	Valley
Camp Bonewatch	Skeleton ×2	Watchtower camp
Camp Patrol	Skeleton + Orc	Watchtower camp
Camp Muscle	Orc	Watchtower camp
D1 Ambush	Skeleton + Evil Mage	Dungeon chamber 1
D2 Barricade	Bishop Knight + Lizard Warrior	Dungeon chamber 2
D3 Threshold	Orc + Evil Mage	Dungeon chamber 3
Fork Rat Den	Rat Assassin ×2	Dungeon fork, south branch
Warlord Fight	Warlord + summons	Dungeon boss: flagged as the run-ending fight

The Warlord

90 HP. Worth 100 Gold.

Beat	Name	Effect
1	**Ascend**	+2 Strength to himself.

Beat	Name	Effect
2	**Cleave**	18 damage + 2 strength = 20 damage
3	**Guard**	12 Block and 5 Attack
4	**Call the Horde**	Summons a Risen Skeleton and a Bound Hexer, capped at two living summons

Economy

Gold

Gold is the only currency, dropped by defeated enemies, and there is **no meta-currency between runs**.

You start a run with **200 gold** (enough for one Rare, or two Uncommons, or a heal plus a removal plus change), so the first Shop visit is already a real decision. Rewards run 10g (Slime) to 50g (Orc) for ordinary enemies and 100g for the Warlord.

The Shop

Walk into the doorway of the house in the valley to enter the shop. The header reuses the exploration HUD's own HP bar and gold counter.

Action	Cost	What it does
Buy a card	40 / 75 / 130g	By rarity. Adds the card to your deck immediately.
Reroll the stock	25g	Re-rolls all six offers
Remove a card	60g	Cuts a card from the deck, down to a floor of 5 cards. The button flips to "Back" while you are choosing.
Heal	30g	Restores you to full
Buy a potion	40g	Health, Energy or Draw; you can carry 3

Stock. Six cards, rolled once per run and drawn without replacement from a rarity-weighted pool of sixteen. Weights are 6 / 3 / 1 by rarity, so Commons dominate the window and a Rare is genuinely uncommon. Each offer shows its rarity and price permanently on the cost line.

Potions and World Rewards

Source	Reward	Limit
Health Potion	+12 HP	Carry 3 total; combat use only, via click or 1 / 2 / 3
Energy Potion	+2 energy this turn	As above
Draw Potion	Draw 2 cards	As above
Heal fountain	Heal at the Dungeon entrance	Beginning of dungeon
Fork healing fountain	Heals a chunk of HP	Fork, north branch
Rat assassins	Black Hole, added straight to the deck	Fork, south branch
Waterfall cave chest	100 gold	Once per run, unsignposted

Source	Reward	Limit
Potion pickups	One potion	Placed after encounter 1 and before encounter 3

World and Narrative

The player controls Ace, a young Deckborn. Deckborn are sorcerers who channel their spells through a deck of cards.

Cast

- **Ace.** The player character.
- **Jack.** NPC who gives player their main goal and starts the timer.
- **The Warlord.** The final boss; he wants to plunge the valley into darkness.

Interface

Visual Target

Cell-shaded anime inspired art style. Closest comparable is Dragon Quest 11.

UI Identity

One visual language across every screen: **royal purple fills with gold outlines**, in the Firlest display face for titles.

Surface	Treatment
Combat HUD	Hero plate with 34px rounded HP and Block pills, gold captions, numbers nested inside the bars, a purple MANA pill with a gold rim, and three colour-coded potion chips along the bottom. Nine animated HUD behaviours and a phase-coloured turn banner: violet on the player turn, crimson on the enemy turn.
Enemy plates	Overhead world-anchored panels per enemy showing name, HP, block and the next intent, in the same purple and gold.
Cards	Per-card art, background colour by function, live-tinted damage and block numbers, hover pop-out, and drop slots in matching purple and gold.
Exploration HUD	A gold-outer, purple-inner rounded HP pill with a gold readout chip beneath it, plus the run clock.
Dialogue	One dialogue box asset serves Jack, the Warlord and every sign: purple panel, gold rim, speaker name top-left, and the “[E]” advance prompt split out into a gold capsule in the bottom-right corner.
Deck & shop menus	Shared header / grid / footer chrome, a vertical wrapping card grid, and a live deck-count readout.
Menus	All 20 buttons share one primary / secondary style with real hover, press and disabled states and 2px of press travel.
End screens	Victory, Skirmish Victory and Defeat each animate in, on one title treatment.

Keyword Tooltips

One shared glossary widget explains eleven keywords (Block, Strength, Weak, Vulnerable, Frail, Poison, Exhaust and the rest) on hover, across five surfaces: the combat hand, the shop, the deck menu, the enemy intent line, and the hero’s own status readout. The wording is read out of the combat code, so the tooltip and the rule cannot drift apart. Because the HUD abbreviates status names, each keyword carries an alias so hovering “Vuln 2” still finds Vulnerable.

Camera and Controls

Input	Exploration	Combat
W / A / S / D	Move	—

Input	Exploration	Combat
Mouse	Look	Drag a card onto a target
E	Talk, read a sign, advance dialogue	—
Q	Deck menu	—
1 / 2 / 3	—	Use potion slot
Escape / P	Pause	Pause

Third-person follow camera with a per-level profile: the Valley wide and open, the Dungeon over-the-shoulder at 170 arm length and 75 FOV. Combat hands off to a six-camera director rig: the Valley blends between shots, the Dungeon cuts.

Audio

Music

Used 16-Bit Fantasy and Adventure Music Pack from itch by user XDeviruchi. Each level has their own music:

Level	Music
Title Screen	Falling Apart (Prologue)
Valley	The Journey
Combat	Battle 1 or Battle 2
Victory	Victory!
Defeat	Frozen Abyss
Dungeon	Lost Shrine
Warlord	Decisive Battle 2 - The Calamity

Sound Effects

Combat SFX ride the same rails as the VFX (cast, enemy intent, impact and death), with per-card overrides, function-based fallbacks, and pitch jitter scaled by hit weight, so a heavy hit sounds heavier rather than just louder. UI SFX cover hover and click on every button, plus confirm, error, open, close and reward cues for the shop and menus.

Production

Technical

Area	Implementation
Engine	Unreal Engine 5.8. **Blueprint-only**. No gameplay C++. All game logic under Content/Deckborn/.
Combat data	Cards, enemies, intents and encounters are Data Assets; statuses are GameplayTags.
Persistence	A GameInstance carries HP, gold, deck, potions, cleared-enemy ids, shop stock, death count and the run clock across level loads. Nothing is written to disk.
Rules vs. presentation	BP_TurnManager is the referee; BP_JuiceManager stages everything it announces. The presentation layer cannot change a number.
Hero	BP_DeckbornHero, sprint speed 750, hand-rolled invertible mouse look.
Art & anim packs	SoStylized environment, Fantastic Dungeon Pack, ScriptWizardAnimSet (hero card animations), Vefects stylized / anime VFX, Nhance spell icons, Magic Spell UI + SFX pack.

Standalone project Scope

Deckborn is a standalone game, not a vertical slice or a proof of concept for a larger title. Everything below is in the build.

Area	Scope	Status
Core loop	Explore → fight → spend → Dungeon → boss	Complete
Cards	22 cards, 3 rarities, 2 archetypes	Complete
Enemies & encounters	12 enemies, 13 encounters, 1 boss	Complete
World	2 traversable zones, 2 combat stages, 1 menu map	Complete, dressed and lit
Economy	Gold, shop, removal, potions, world rewards	Complete
Presentation	Camera director, per-card animation, Niagara VFX, damage numbers	Complete
UI	Every screen wired on one purple-and-gold identity	Complete
Audio	Music, combat SFX, UI SFX, stings	Complete
Balance	Gold curve, clock length, boss difficulty	**Complete**
Packaged build	Cook verification per content pass	**Complete**

What It Deliberately Is Not

These are not roadmap items. They are decisions about what this game is.

Not in the game	Why
Save and continue	A run is one sitting. Quitting ends it.
Meta-progression	No unlocks, no currency between runs. Every run starts from the same 12 cards and 200 gold.
Character creation	The hero has a fixed name and appearance.
Multiple acts or dungeons	One Valley, one Dungeon, one boss.
Relics	The data type exists; no relics are authored.
An exploration card deck	Cards are a combat verb. Vestigial flags survive on the card asset, but nothing reads them.
Difficulty settings	One tuning.